KINGDOM LIFE MINISTRY

Fire on the Fiftieth Day

Shavuot: Count the Weeks, Receive the Spirit, Write His Instructions on the Heart

A Midrash Study on the Feast of Weeks, Leviticus 23:15-22

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with Yahshua and Messiah restored. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Fifty days after the first sheaf was waved, YHWH told his people to bring two loaves of new wheat bread before him, rest, gather, and rejoice with everyone in their gates.

On that same appointed day, after Yahshua rose, the disciples were gathered in one place when fire came from heaven and the Spirit was poured out. Pentecost is not a church holiday that replaced a Hebrew feast. **Pentecost is Shavuot.** It always was.

HOW TO READ THIS HANDOUT

Commanded means the instruction is written plainly. **Interpretive** means a reasonable reading Scripture does not state outright. **Conviction** means it is how we at Kingdom Life walk it out. Where Scripture stops speaking, we do not call our reading a commandment.

SECTION I

The Appointed Time Itself

> *You shall count from the next day after the Sabbath, from the day that you brought the sheaf of the wave offering: seven Sabbaths shall be completed. The next day after the seventh Sabbath you shall count fifty days; and you shall offer a new meal offering to YHWH.*
> **LEVITICUS 23:15-16**

> *On the same day you shall make proclamation: there shall be a holy convocation to you. You shall do no regular work. This is a statute forever in all your dwellings throughout your generations.*
> **LEVITICUS 23:21**

Shavuot is the only appointed time with no fixed date in the text. It is **counted**. Start on the day the first sheaf was waved, count seven complete weeks, and the next day, the fiftieth, is the feast. It is a holy convocation and a day of rest, and YHWH calls it a statute forever **in all your dwellings**. **Commanded.**

The Words

- ***Shavua (H7620), plural shavuot.*** A week, a period of seven. *Chag Shavuot* is the feast of weeks (Exodus 34:22; Deuteronomy 16:10).
- ***Sapar (H5608).*** To count, to number, to recount. The same verb is used for telling YHWH's works (Psalm 9:1). You shall *count* (Leviticus 23:15).
- ***Temimot.*** Complete, whole. Seven Sabbaths **shall be completed** (Leviticus 23:15), from *tamim*, the word for whole, perfect, without blemish.
- ***Yom HaBikkurim.*** The day of the first fruits (Numbers 28:26). Shavuot is the firstfruits of the wheat harvest (Exodus 34:22), just as the omer was the first of the barley.
- ***Pentekoste (G4005).*** Fiftieth. The Greek name for the day, from the fifty days of Leviticus 23:16. When Acts 2:1 says the day of Pentecost had come, it is naming Shavuot.
- ***Symplerousthai (G4845).*** To be filled up completely. Acts 2:1 says the day **was being fully come**, the count of fifty filled to the last day.

SECTION II

Count It Yourself

There is something personal in a feast that must be counted. Israel had to pay attention every day for seven weeks. You cannot stumble onto Shavuot; you have to be watching for it. A people who are counting toward a day are a people who expect something to happen on it.

Conviction: at Kingdom Life we count from Firstfruits on the first day of the week, so Shavuot always falls on the day after the seventh weekly Sabbath, the first day of the week. That follows the plain reading of seven Sabbaths and the next day after the seventh Sabbath (Leviticus 23:15-16). The rabbinic calendar counts from the sixteenth of the month instead and fixes Shavuot on the sixth of the third month. See the Firstfruits handout for both readings and the Septuagint note.

SECTION III

Two Loaves Baked With Leaven

> *You shall bring out of your habitations two loaves of bread for a wave offering made of two tenths of an ephah of fine flour. They shall be baked with yeast, for first fruits to YHWH.*
> **LEVITICUS 23:17**

Seven weeks earlier, every trace of leaven was put out of the house. Now YHWH asks for bread **baked with leaven** and waved before him. Grain offerings burned on the altar could not contain leaven (Leviticus 2:11), but these two loaves were waved, not burned, and they are called firstfruits. **Stated in the text.**

What do the two loaves picture? We hold that they picture the two houses of Israel, Judah and Ephraim, the two sticks YHWH promises to make one in his hand (Ezekiel 37:15-22). Leavened bread pictures a people who still carry sin and are not yet perfected, yet are accepted before him as his firstfruits because of the offering made with them (Leviticus 23:18-20). **Conviction.** Others see Jew and Gentile made one new man (Ephesians 2:14-16). Scripture does not say what the two loaves represent, so we hold our reading humbly.

SAY IT PLAINLY

YHWH does not wait until you are perfect to receive you. On the day he poured out his Spirit, he received leavened loaves as firstfruits. **He accepts his people as they are, and then he writes his instructions on their hearts.**

SECTION IV

Sinai: Fire, Sound, and His Instructions

Israel came to the wilderness of Sinai in the third month after leaving Egypt (Exodus 19:1). On the third day YHWH came down on the mountain in fire, with thunder, lightning, a thick cloud, and the sound of a shofar growing louder and louder (Exodus 19:16-19). Then he spoke the ten words and gave his instructions to his people.

Many teach that Sinai happened on the day of Shavuot. Exodus 19 places it in the third month, which fits the fifty day window after the Exodus, but the text **never says** the instructions were given on the feast day, and Leviticus 23 never connects Shavuot to Sinai. That link comes from later Jewish tradition. **Interpretive.** The timing is close, and the parallels with Acts 2 are real, but we will not call it a stated fact.

What Sinai and Acts 2 Share

- **Fire from heaven.** YHWH descended on Sinai in fire (Exodus 19:18). Tongues like fire sat on each of the disciples (Acts 2:3).
- **A sound.** At Sinai, a growing sound of the shofar (Exodus 19:19). In Jerusalem, a sound from the sky like a rushing mighty wind (Acts 2:2).
- **Three thousand.** After the golden calf, about three thousand men fell (Exodus 32:28). After Peter preached, about three thousand souls were added (Acts 2:41). The letter kills, the Spirit gives life (2 Corinthians 3:6). **The numbers are stated; the contrast is interpretive.**
- **Written on stone, written on hearts.** At Sinai the ten words were written on tablets of stone by the finger of Elohim (Exodus 31:18). Paul says believers are a letter written by the Spirit of the living Elohim, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts (2 Corinthians 3:3).

SECTION V

The Spirit Poured Out on Shavuot

> *Now when the day of Pentecost had come, they were all with one accord in one place. Suddenly there came from the sky a sound like the rushing of a mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. Tongues like fire appeared and were distributed to them, and one sat on each of them. They were all filled with the Holy Spirit, and began to speak with other languages, as the Spirit gave them the ability to speak.*
> **ACTS 2:1-4**

Yahshua had told them to wait in Jerusalem for the promise of the Father (Acts 1:4). They did not wait for a random day. They were gathered on an appointed time, keeping the feast, and that is when the Father kept his promise. The disciples were not starting a new religion with a new holiday. They were keeping Shavuot.

The New Covenant Promise

Jeremiah prophesied a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, in which YHWH would put his instructions in their inward parts and write them on their hearts (Jeremiah 31:31-33). Ezekiel explains how:

> *I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes, and you will keep my ordinances and do them.*
> **EZEKIEL 36:27**

This is the key to Shavuot for every believer. The Spirit was not given to replace YHWH's instructions. The Spirit was given to **cause us to walk in them**. What was written on stone at Sinai is written on the heart by the Spirit. **Stated in the text.**

Peter said what was happening was what the prophet Joel spoke of: I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh (Acts 2:16-17; Joel 2:28-32). And he ended with an open door: **the promise is to you, and to your children, and to all who are far off** (Acts 2:39). Isaiah used the same words, peace to him who is far off and to him who is near (Isaiah 57:19), and Paul used them for the Gentiles brought near by the blood of Messiah (Ephesians 2:13, 17).

SECTION VI

Ruth: A Foreigner in the Harvest

The book of Ruth is set inside the very season of the count. Naomi and Ruth arrived in Bethlehem **in the beginning of barley harvest** (Ruth 1:22), and Ruth gleaned in the fields of Boaz **to the end of barley harvest and of wheat harvest** (Ruth 2:23). That is the span from the first sheaf to the wheat of Shavuot. **Stated in the text.**

Ruth was a Moabite, the one nation Torah said should not enter the assembly (Deuteronomy 23:3). But she said to Naomi, **your people will be my people, and your Elohim my Elohim** (Ruth 1:16), and she came to rest under the wings of the Elohim of Israel (Ruth 2:12). She was redeemed by a kinsman, married into Judah, and became the great grandmother of David and part of the line of Messiah (Ruth 4:13-22; Matthew 1:5).

> **A NOTE ON TRADITION**
> Reading Ruth at Shavuot is a rabbinic custom, not a commandment, and we do not present it as one. But you do not need the custom to see the point. **The text itself puts a grafted in foreigner in the fields of Bethlehem between the barley and the wheat.**

SECTION VII

Keeping Shavuot Without the Temple

Leviticus 23:17-20 commands the two loaves to be waved, along with burnt offerings, a sin offering, and peace offerings, all by the priest. Deuteronomy 16:16 calls Shavuot one of the three times the males appear before YHWH **in the place which he chooses**. None of that can be done without the altar and the place, and we do not invent substitutes (Deuteronomy 12:13-14). **Commanded, and not something we can do now.**

But of all the spring feasts, Shavuot carries the strongest words for keeping it wherever you live:

- **In all your dwellings.** The holy convocation and the rest are a statute forever **in all your dwellings throughout your generations** (Leviticus 23:21). The Hebrew *moshav* (H4186) is a dwelling place, where you live. **Commanded.**
- **Count the fifty days.** (Leviticus 23:15-16; Deuteronomy 16:9). **Commanded.**
- **Rest and gather.** No regular work, and a holy convocation (Leviticus 23:21). **Commanded.**
- **Rejoice with everyone in your gates.** Your son, your daughter, your servants, the Levite, the stranger, the fatherless, and the widow (Deuteronomy 16:11). **Commanded.**
- **Give a freewill offering as he has blessed you.** (Deuteronomy 16:10). **Commanded** in principle; we give it to people and ministries in need rather than to an altar.
- **Remember you were a slave.** (Deuteronomy 16:12). **Commanded.**
- **Leave the corners for the poor and the foreigner.** Right after the Shavuot instructions, YHWH says do not reap the corners of your field or gather the gleanings, but leave them for the poor and for the foreigner (Leviticus 23:22). **Commanded.** For most of us today that means deliberately setting aside part of what we have for those who have nothing.

The Apostles Marked It Wherever They Were

Paul wrote from Ephesus, **I will stay at Ephesus until Pentecost** (1 Corinthians 16:8). Later he hurried to reach Jerusalem for the day of Pentecost if possible (Acts 20:16). Whether he was in the land or outside it, Paul kept time by Shavuot. And the crowd at Acts 2 was made of people from every nation under the sky, scattered far from the land, who had come to keep the feast (Acts 2:5-11).

SECTION VIII

What We Leave Out and Why

Rabbinic tradition added an all night study, dairy foods, decorating with greenery, and reading Ruth, and it treats the day mainly as the anniversary of the giving of the Torah. Church tradition calls the day Pentecost Sunday, fixes it from the Easter date, and has largely forgotten that it was ever a harvest feast of YHWH at all.

We do not need either one. Scripture gives us the count, the rest, the gathering, the rejoicing with the stranger and the widow, the corners left for the poor, and the outpoured Spirit. That is more than enough to fill a day. **Where Scripture speaks, we follow it. Where it is silent, we do not add a commandment** (Mark 7:7-9).

SECTION IX

Filled With the Spirit, Emptied of Grudges

On Shavuot the disciples were **all with one accord in one place** (Acts 2:1). The Greek *homothumadon* (G3661) means with one mind, one passion. The Spirit fell on a group of people who had stopped competing over who was greatest (Luke 22:24) and were praying together (Acts 1:14).

You cannot be of one accord with someone you will not forgive. Paul tells us not to grieve the Holy Spirit, and in the same breath, to put away all bitterness, wrath, and anger, and to forgive one another as Elohim in Messiah forgave us (Ephesians 4:30-32). If you are counting toward the day of the Spirit, spend those fifty days clearing out what

grieves him.

> THE ORDER OF THINGS
>
> **Humility is the root of forgiveness. Forgiveness is the root of deliverance.** And a heart that has let go is a heart with room to be filled.

SECTION X

Walking It Out

1. **Count from Firstfruits.** Mark day one on the calendar and count each day. Read a psalm or a chapter of Acts each week as you count.
2. **Use the count to clean house.** Seven weeks, seven areas of the heart. Ask the Spirit to show you what grieves him.
3. **Rest on the fiftieth day.** No regular work. Gather your household and others, read Leviticus 23:15-22, Acts 2, and Ruth.
4. **Rejoice with the stranger and the widow.** Invite someone who has no one to celebrate with.
5. **Leave the corners.** Set aside a portion to give to the poor and the foreigner, as Leviticus 23:22 says.
6. **Ask for the Spirit.** Yahshua said the Father will give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him (Luke 11:13). Ask him to write his instructions on your heart.

SECTION XI

Cross Reference Index

Primary texts: Leviticus 23:15-22; Deuteronomy 16:9-12; Numbers 28:26-31; Exodus 34:22; Acts 2:1-41

The count: Leviticus 23:15-16; Deuteronomy 16:9

The two loaves: Leviticus 23:17-20; Leviticus 2:11-12; Ezekiel 37:15-22; Ephesians 2:14-16

Sinai: Exodus 19:1-19; Exodus 20:1-21; Exodus 31:18; Exodus 32:28

The new covenant: Jeremiah 31:31-34; Ezekiel 36:26-27; 2 Corinthians 3:3-6; Hebrews 8:8-10

The Spirit poured out: Joel 2:28-32; Luke 24:49; Acts 1:4-8, 14; Acts 2:1-21, 38-41; Luke 11:13

Far off and near: Isaiah 57:19; Acts 2:39; Ephesians 2:13, 17

Ruth: Ruth 1:16, 22; Ruth 2:12, 23; Ruth 4:13-22; Deuteronomy 23:3; Matthew 1:5

Outside the land: Acts 2:5-11; Acts 20:16; 1 Corinthians 16:8; Leviticus 23:21

Rejoicing and giving: Deuteronomy 16:10-12; Leviticus 23:22; Leviticus 19:9-10

One accord and forgiveness: Acts 1:14; Acts 2:1, 46; Luke 22:24-27; Ephesians 4:30-32

NOTES

Personal Notes and Convictions

Kingdom Life Ministry
Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.

Walk in truth, walk in light. Shalom.